

Maria Silva

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Dear Hiring Manager,

I am applying for the Child Protection Paralegal role at the local authority legal team because family and child protection work sits at the heart of what drew me to public-facing legal practice, and my background in case management, client-facing advice and preparing court materials gives me a practical foundation for the responsibilities involved.

At BCLP, I managed case files across two rotations involving competing deadlines and high document volumes. In international arbitration, I tracked procedural deadlines, coordinated documents across a multilingual team and became the sole junior supporting the matter shortly before a significant submission deadline. In real estate disputes, I prepared electronic hearing bundles, assisted with court filings and maintained matter records on iManage. I am comfortable working in case management systems and have used electronic bundling tools as a routine part of the role, so the requirement for proficiency in IKEN or a comparable platform and electronic court bundle systems is one I can meet from a standing start.

Since July 2026 I have been advising clients at Citizens Advice East Berkshire on welfare benefits, housing, family and debt matters. Many of my clients are in vulnerable circumstances, and the work requires taking detailed factual statements, identifying evidential gaps, drafting correspondence and managing files from first instruction through to submission, all while communicating procedural requirements clearly to people under significant stress. That experience of handling sensitive casework with real consequences for clients, and translating complex procedural rules into practical guidance, is directly relevant to supporting child protection proceedings, where clarity and accuracy in preparation matter enormously.

I have not used the Family Proceedings Portal directly, but I have filed documents through electronic court portals at BCLP and have learned case management systems quickly in previous roles. I want to be straightforward about that gap rather than overstate my experience.

This role appeals because child protection work involves exactly the combination of careful procedural preparation and genuine client impact that I find most meaningful. The interim nature suits my current availability, and working within a local authority legal team would give me structured exposure to public law family proceedings that I am keen to develop.

Yours sincerely,
Maria Silva